

On the Language of the Argippaei: An Ancient Predecessor of Mongolic?

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1. Introduction

The Argippaei, as we know from Herodotus, are an ancient Asian people who are said to possess a number of innate features such as baldness, sacredness and peacefulness. Their linguistic and ethnic affiliations have been the subject of long and rather fruitless discussions. Although these have lasted for over a century, they have not yielded any conclusive or at least satisfying etymology for the lexemes attributed to the language of the Argippaei by Herodotus. The most fundamental reason for this failure appears to be the obsession to find an Iranian origin for the Argippaei. Another reason may lie in the fragmentary and unfocused way with which the subject has been dealt, and that it has been examined primarily by historians.

The present study directly focuses on the four lexical items given by Herodotus, namely ἄσχυ, ποντικόν, Ἀργιππᾶιοι and Ἀρμῆσποι / Ἀρμάσπεα, and elaborates on them from a fresh perspective. After a brief discussion of the nonlinguistic aspects of the Argippaei, each lexeme will be discussed separately beginning with reviews of earlier etymological attempts and for each one, a detailed etymology will be proposed.

2. On the Argippaei and Their Location

The passage in which Herodotus refers to the Argippaei in *The Histories* is given beneath.

[23] Up to the land of these Scythians, the terrain of the countries mentioned is uniformly even and has a deep layer of soil, but then it becomes rocky and rugged. Far past this rugged region, in the foothills of a mountain range, live people who are said – men and women alike – to be bald from birth; they are also supposed to have snub noses and large chins, to have a distinct language, to dress like Scythians, and to live off trees. The tree is called *pontikos*, and is about the same size as a fig-tree; its fruit looks like a bean, but has a pit inside. When the fruit is ripe, they strain it through cloths and extract a thick, dark juice from it, which they call *askhu*. They lick this juice and drink it mixed with milk, and compress the thickest sediment into cakes for eating. They do not have much livestock, because the grazing there is poor. They each live under a tree, and wrap white waterproof felt around their trees in

winter, while dispensing with the felt in summer. They are said to be holy, and so no one acts unjustly towards them, and they do not have any weapons of war. When disputes arise between neighbouring tribes, they are the ones who settle them, and any fugitive who takes refuge among them is safe from unjust treatment. They are called the Argippaei.

[24] Now, there is a great deal of good information available about the land and all the tribes up to and including these bald people, because Scythians sometimes reach these parts, as do Greeks from the trading-centre Borysthenes and from other trading-centres on the Euxine Sea, and it is not hard to get information from them. The Scythians who travel to these tribes conduct their business in seven languages, each requiring its own translator (Herodotus 1998: 242–243).

The following points about the Argippaei may immediately be inferred from the passage above:

- They are Mongoloid (Minns 1913: 108; Phillips 1957: 162; Phillips 1960: 126).
- They speak a language other than “Scythian”.
- They are culturally influenced by the Scythians.
- They are sedentary and live in a primitive form of *yurts* (Phillips 1960: 126; Asheri et al. 2007: 598).
- Their economy is based on trade and not on livestock breeding or agriculture.
- They are not warlike and do not participate in fights and battles.
- They have a drink called ἄσχυ in their native language, which is produced from the fruit of a tree called ποντικός.

Other statements of Herodotus regarding the Argippaei, such as their baldness and sacredness, are inconclusive. They may have shaved their heads for ritual purposes (Phillips 1955: 168; Phillips 1960: 127–128) but innate baldness seems less possible. Their reputed sacredness might have been a false interpretation made by outsiders.

One of the issues much discussed about the Argippaei is their location. Tomaschek (1889: 56) argues that the Argippaei must be located in the southern part of the Altai Mountains. Minns (1913: 108) likewise places them in Dzungaria, which lies between the Altai and the Tian Shan. Hudson (1924: 159–160) states that the identification of “the lofty and precipitous mountains” with the Urals, the Altai, and the Hindu Kush by different authorities is acceptable. Phillips (1955: 165–169; 1960: 124–128) identifies “the lofty mountains” of Herodotus with the Urals and places the Argippaei in the Southern Urals. Haussig (1980: 17; 1983: 18) who equates the Argippaei to the *Argu* in the Old Turkic sources claims that they must be located in the Ili Valley. Cunliffe (2015: 233) reckons that “the lofty mountains” is a reference to the Altai.¹

1 A more detailed summary of the earlier studies can be found in Phillips (1955: 168) and Asheri et al. (2007: 598–599).

According to Rennell (1830: 177–178), the Argippaei must have occupied “the northern part of the tract, now in the possession of *Greater or Eastern Horde* of the *Kirgees*”. Rennell also refers to the mountains named *Arga* and *Argia* in the map of Strahlenberg and in the Map of Russia. The mountains which are called *Arga-Tau* or *Arkaula* in the map of Strahlenberg (*Nova Descriptio Geographica Tatariae Magnae*, 1730) are probably today’s Qurama Mountains that are located in the southwest of Talas. This location is almost in agreement with the statement of Kāšgarī who calls the land between Tīrāz and Balāsāgūn *Argu*. This region was mainly occupied by the Saka at the time of Herodotus (Bregel 2003: 7).² If there is a real connection between the Old Turkic *Argu*, Strahlenberg’s *Arga-Tau* / *Arkaula* and the Argippaei, the most probable location for the Argippaei appears to be around the Fergana Valley. If the identification of ποντικός with the bird cherry (*Prunus padus*) is accepted, we see that this localization is also consistent with the distribution of the tree, as it is found in the Osh and Chuy provinces of Kyrgyzstan (Zaurov et al. 2013: 183), and even in many regions of Kazakhstan (Dzhangaliev et al. 2003: 329).

3. The Language of the Argippaei

3.1 ἄσχυ

The word occurs in Herodotus only once in 4, 23³ (Powell 1938: 50). The word ἄσχυ is of special significance since it may help us to identify the language spoken by the Argippaei, which, as is stated by Herodotus, is not identical with that of the Scythians.

There have been only few etymological attempts to assign the word to any known language. Tomaschek (1889: 59–60) proposes various Turkic and Mongolic etymologies. These may be given in modern transcription as follows: Trk. *sik-* ‘to squeeze, press, compress’ (EDPT: 804–805); Mo. *aska-* ‘to pour out, sprinkle, spill, scatter’ (N: 274); Mo. *ačuq* ‘viscous’; Trk. *ačig* / *aču* ‘bitter; sour’ (EDPT: 21–22); Trk. *azuk* ‘food for a journey’ (EDPT: 283); Trk. *aš* ‘food’ (Yak. *as*) (EDPT: 253). These etymologies have already been criticized by Németh (1940: 515–516).

Campbell (1890: 101) rather oddly posits a connection between this word and the Peruvian *asahua*, referring to Rivero-Tschudi (1855: 198). Minns (1913: 109), Phillips (1960: 126), Haussig (1979: 118; 1980: 17) and Asheri et al. (2007: 598)

2 Another remarkable notation in the map of Strahlenberg is the *Tribus Argun* right at the western foot of the Mountain *Arga-Tau* / *Arkaula*. The tribal name *Argun*, which is attested from the Middle Turkic period on, is still widespread among the Kazakhs and Uzbeks (Akbiyık 2002: 9–14, 24). Both in Turkic and Mongolic, it is also used as a proper name with a rather obscure etymology (Rybatzki 2006: 153). Marco Polo, who refers to the *Argon*, states that they are produced from a mixture of two races. This suggestion makes the Old Turkic word *arkun* ‘cross-bred’ (EDPT: 216) much more likely for the origin of *Argun*. Whether Polo’s statement reflects an aetiological etymology and *Argun* is somehow related to the ancient toponym and ethnonym *Argu* is unclear.

identify ἄσχυ with various medieval or modern forms of the Turkic word *ačig* ‘bitter’ (EDPT: 21–22), which can hardly be correct considering that the earliest form of the word must be reconstructed as **pǎčigǎ* (KhM: 290). Herzfeld (1947: 557, as cited in Phillips 1960: 126), on the other hand, considers it to be Iranian and relates it to the words *ansu* and *asu*. However, what is called *aṃśu* in Vedic and *qsu* in Avestan (both of which go back to **anču* < **ank’u*) is not the drink itself but the stalk from which *Soma* is extracted (Kapadia 1959: 31; Witzel 2003: 37). Moreover, ἄσχυ and the Iranian forms in question are not the best phonetic matches. Nikić (2009: 23) sees a connection between ἄσχυ and the Sanskrit *āscut* ‘to sprinkle’ < *ścut* ‘to shed, pour out; distilling’. As can be seen, none of the etymologies given above are convincing.

In my opinion, the word ἄσχυ is genuinely Mongolic if that term is taken in a wide sense. WM *esüg* ~ *üsüg* ‘sour beverage, koumiss made from mare’s milk; leaven’ (MED: 335), SH *esuk* ‘Stutenmilch, abgegossene Milch’ (Haenisch 1962: 46), HY *äsük* ‘lait de jument’ (Lewicki 1959: 16), Khal. *ösög* ‘kumys; kislyj napi-tok’ (Luvsandэндэв 1957: 332), Khal. *ösög* ‘ajrag cegee’ (Cèvel 1966: 447) and Ord. *esuk* ~ *usuk* ‘koumys fait avec du lait de jument’ (Mostaert 1968: 249, 764) point to PM **esüg*, which is a perfect candidate for being a cognate of the Argippaeon ἄσχυ. The Mongolic word appears to have originally signified ‘sour beverage’, which fits well to the description of ἄσχυ. Other meanings of the word such as ‘koumiss’, on the other hand, must be secondary.

If Herodotus’ ἄσχυ indeed points to a back vocalic pronunciation **asku*, it must have undergone two sound changes, namely vowel fronting and metathesis, before surfacing as **esüg* in Mongolic. Some indirect evidence for a vowel fronting in Pre-Proto-Mongolic is not lacking: PM **keriye* ‘crow’ (N: 411) must go back to PPM **kariga* if it has its origin in the Turkic word **kariga* ‘crow’ (> OT *karga*) (Ünal 2016: 760).³ On the other hand, the back vowels might be the Greek representation of the Pre-Proto-Mongolic open-mid [ɛ] or near-open [æ], which are possible realizations of the phoneme /e/, or the word may have been phonetically distorted by an intermediary language.

The Proto-Mongolic **esüg* shows that Herodotus’ ἄσχυ may be indicating an ancient Pre-Proto-Mongolic form of the same word. At first glance, it cannot be ruled out that PM **esüg* is a direct or indirect loanword from the language of the Argippaei. However, in the following part of the study, I will try to show that this is not the case considering that all the lexemes ascribed by Herodotus to the language of the Argippaei can be shown to be Pre-Proto-Mongolic.

3 Other probable instances of a Pre-Proto-Mongolic vowel fronting are as follows (Ünal 2016: 760): Mo. *eresü* ~ *ersü* ‘hermaphrodite’ (MED: 323); OT *aršu* ‘id’. (UWb 204); Mo. *erselej* ‘a fabulous animal’ (MED: 331); OT *aršlan* ‘lion’ (EDPT: 238); perhaps also Mo. *keder* ‘testy, irascible’ (MED: 441); OT *kadīr* ‘grim, brutal’ (EDPT: 603–604).

Considering its etymology, **esüg* may have been derived from the Proto-Mongolic verb **is-* ‘to turn sour, ferment’ (N: 376)⁴ only if it goes back to an earlier form **es-*. For this sound change, a sporadic vowel raising may be accountable of which other instances are already present in Mongolic: PM **bidüyün* ‘coarse, crude’ < **bedü-yün* (N: 283) ← Trk. *bādū-* ‘to be or become big’ (EDPT: 299); PM **isegei* ‘felt’ (N: 376–377)⁵ < **egese(i)* ← Trk. **ākčä ~ käčä* ‘felt’ (EDPT: 694).⁶

In Turkic, there seems to be no cognate of *ṣṣḡḡ*. Similar words such as Chuv. *yaška* ‘obščee nazvanie pervyx bljud: poxlëbka, šči, sup’ (ČRS: 651), Tuv. *čažig* (< **yašig?*) ‘svjaščennaja židkost’ (napr. moloko, araka, ajran) razbryzgi vaemaja pri soveršenii obrjadov kul’ta’ (Tenišev 1968: 508) and Muh. *yaksun* ‘arpa şiresi’ (Battal 1934: 84; TMEN II No. 723; EDPT: 320) are also found in Turkic. However, none of these lexemes have a wide distribution within Turkic languages and they cannot be considered as a cognate of *ṣṣḡḡ* from the phonetic and semantic aspect.

The Chinese 醍醐 *tī-hú* ‘clear koumiss; clarified butter; whey’⁷, which first appears in 說文解字 *Shuōwén jiězì* (Pulleyblank 1962: 255), might have been borrowed from the Xianbei **etkü*, a hypothetical variant of PPM **eskü* which represents an intermediate stage between the Argippaeian **asku* and PM **esüg*. A similar alternation of the word-medial consonant clusters *sk* and *tk* is also observed in PM **heske- ~ *hetke-* ‘to cut’ and PM **ödken ~ *ösken* ‘thick, dense’ (N: 351–352, 470), of which the former is probably a loanword from the Turkic **eskä-* (> DLT *iskä-* ‘to pluck out’) (EDPT: 246).

Pulleyblank (1962: 255) compares the Chinese word with the Mongolic *čige(n)*⁸ assuming that it goes back to **tigä(n)* or **iiga(n)*. However, Mo. **čegeen* ‘koumiss’ is simply a phonetic and semantic development from **čagaan* ‘white’ (< **ča-i-* ‘to become white of bright’) (N: 298). The word appears with its back vocalic variant as a loanword in Manchu *čahan* ‘buttermilk, sour milk’ (Norman 1978: 40; MT: 116). Thus, it is impossible to argue that it goes back to **tigä(n)* or **iiga(n)*. It simply comes from PM **čagayan* ‘white’. Bailey (1985: 31–32) compares the word with the Avestan *tayu-* whereas Dybo (n.d.: 9) sees its origin in the Middle Iranian **doga-(ya)*. Recently, Vovin (2003: 392–393) proposed a connection with the Proto-Yeniseic **täk-* or **tik-* ‘white’ (especially Kott *the:gam*, *the:kam* and Assan *tegama*, *tekama*), which certainly offers a more convincing etymology than the previous

4 Cf. Khal. *is-* ~ *es-* ‘zakisat’, *zakvašivat’sja*; *brodit’*, *podnimat’sja*’ (Luvsandэндэв 1957: 222, 682), Ord. *es-* ‘fermenter, devenir aigre; se gâter (comestibles)’ (Mostaert 1968: 248–249).

5 Note the Written Mongol spelling *esegei*, which probably reflects the Pre-Proto-Mongolic form of the word.

6 Cf. PM **ösegei* ‘heel’ (N 477) < **ögese(i)* ← Trk. *ökčä* ‘heel’ for a similar instance of metathesis and the correspondence of the Mongolic /s/ with the Turkic /č/.

7 MC *t^hiei-yuo*, LH *t^he-ga* (t^he-gs?), OCM **thê?-gâ* (Schuessler 2009: 46, 124).

8 Cf. WM *čige(n)* ~ *čege(n)* ‘mare’s milk, kumiss’ (MED: 179), Khal. *cegee(n)* ‘kumys’ (Luvsandэндэв 1957: 620), Ord. *tš’igē* ‘koumys fait avec du lait de jument’ (Mostaert 1968: 702), Kalm. *tšigēn* ‘kumys’ (Ramstedt 1935: 438).

ones.⁹ However, if the metathesis in 醍醐 *tī-hú* (*tego) can be explained, the Xianbei *etkü would be a more suitable candidate for the foreign origin of the Chinese word. In summary, the history of the word from Herodotus to Mongolic can be shown as follows: *asku (→ ᾗσχυ) > *eskü (~ *etkü) > *esük > Mo. *esüg*.

3.2 ποντικόν

The word occurs in Herodotus only once, as ποντικόν in 4, 23³ (Powell 1938: 314). Tomaschek (1889: 58–59) mentions many plant species while trying to identify ποντικός and concludes that *Prunus padus* is the most probable candidate. However, his etymological explanations concerning ποντικός are unconvincing and imperfect.

According to Minns (1913: 108–109), ποντικός is an Iranian word meaning ‘the way-tree’, ‘travellers’ joy’. Minns agrees with the earlier identification of ποντικός with the bird cherry. Herzfeld (1947: 554–557) proposes to derive ποντικός from the Old Persian *puntaka* ‘from Punt’, which means from South Arabia or Abyssinia, and identifies it with the coffee-tree. This identification is rightly criticised by Phillips (1960: 125–126). Mühlestein (1986: 563n.) states that the cherry tree was named with the adjective ποντικός by Herodotus because a name for this tree was still lacking among the Greeks at this time.

In my opinion, however, ποντικός has nothing to do with the genuine Greek word ποντικός ‘from Pontos’ derived from πόντος ‘sea’ (Frisk 1960–1972: II, 578–579; Beekes 2010: 1221). I rather tend to regard the resemblance as a coincidence, and see a Pre-Proto-Mongolic form in ποντικός. The Mongolic word which is phonetically and semantically closest to ποντικός is *monasun ‘bird cherry’ that surfaces as Khal. *monos*¹⁰ ‘čerëmuxa (derevo)’ (Luvsandëndëv 1957: 242), Bur. *munahan* ‘birdcherry tree’ (Poppe 1981: 388), Bur. (Bargu) *münühü* ‘Maulbeerbaum’ (Poppe 1932: 373), Dag. *monsü* ‘les’ (Poppe 1930: 86), Dag. *monse* ‘a kind of tree’ (Martin 1961: 192) and Dag. *mons* 稠李樹 [bird cherry tree] (Enkhbat 1984: 201). The base of the word is likely to be *mona, which goes back to an older *bona. The Mongolic *mona is borrowed into Manchu as *munari* (< *muna*+*ri*)¹¹ ‘a round exotic fruit that at first tastes bitter then turns sweet when eaten’ (Zaxarov 1875: 897; Norman 1978: 205).¹²

9 Werner (2003: 75–76) seems to favor Vovin’s etymology.

10 Cydenžapov (1991: 46) gives both Khal. *monol* and *monos* for the translation of Bur. *moyhon*.

11 +*ri* is a common suffix forming plant names in Manchu: *gosiheri* ‘a large bitter exotic fruit’ (< *gosiho* ‘bitter’), *honggori* ‘a bell-shaped fruit’ (< *honggon* ‘small bell’), *jušuhuri* ‘an exotic sour fruit’ (< *jušuhun* ‘sour’), *yahari* ‘charcoal fruit’ (< *yaha* ‘charcoal’), *suburi* ‘a sweet-tasting exotic fruit the size of a hen egg that is supposed to sober up a person who is drunk’ (< **subun* ‘sobering’) and others such as *fiyengseri*, *foyori*, *fulheri*, *halfiri*, *hithari*, *jofohori*, *kofori*, *mamyari*, *masiri*, *muhari*, *šulheri*, *šušuri* (Norman 1978).

12 The more common term for ‘bird-cherry’ in Mongolic is **moyil*, which is attested in Written and Middle Mongol and also in Khalkha, Buryat and Dagur. The Dagur *moile* signifies ‘a kind of tree (? blackberry) and its fruit’ (Martin 1961: 191). The same word occurs in Enkhbat (1984: 201) as *moil* 稠李. The Mongolic **moyil* is likely to be a loanword from the Turkic

I argue that the original form represented by *ποντικός* is **bontiko*, which is likely to be the syncopated form of **bonatiko* (< **bonatī+ko*). The last syllable of the word, i.e. *-ko*, can be equated to the one of the suffixes *+kAi*, *+kUi*, *+gAi* and *+gUi* found in the Mongolic plant names such as WM *argui* ‘a kind of plant’, *iraḡui* ‘anemone (plant)’, *manjuḡai* ‘name of a plant’, *manjuḡui* ‘gilly flower’, *suḡai* ‘tamarisk’ and *yaraḡai* ‘cornelian cherry (plant)’.¹³ Dag. *xudikān* ‘iva’ (Todaeva 1986: 179), of which the base comes from PPM **puda* (Krippes 1992: 142), exhibits a certain suffix *+kān* that Dagur may have inherited from a Para-Mongolic **+kon* or **+kun*. An ending similar to Mongolic is also found in the Old Turkic plant names *awilku* ‘the *qurm* tree’ and *tawilku* ‘Spiraea’¹⁴ (cf. OT *tawilgūč* ‘the jujube tree, Zizyphus’) (EDPT 11: 440–441).

It can be assumed that the suffixed and syncopated form **bontiko*, which gave rise to Herodotus’ *ποντικός*, coexisted with its base **bonatī*. The development of the base **bonatī*¹⁵ to the Pre-Proto-Mongolic **bona* appears to be an analogical process. Similar reanalyses have also been involved in forming of Mo. **sü(n)* ‘milk’ (N: 507), *mindasu(n)* ‘floss-silk, silk thread’ (Lewicki 1959: 60; MED: 539), (*ča-sun-u*) *kör* ‘packed snowdrift’ (MED: 490), *kükür* ‘sulphur’ (MED: 499) and *aṅgir* ‘mandarin duck’ (Haenisch 1962: 8; Lewicki 1959: 10; MED: 44–45), which have their origins in PT **sūt* ‘milk’ (EDPT: 798; KhM: 304), OT *bīndatu* ~ *bīntadu* ~ *mīndatu* ‘silk’ (Zieme 1997: 150–151), Trk. **kört(ün)* ~ **kürt(ün)* ‘snowdrift’ (VEWT: 311), MT (Qışaş al-anbiyā) *kükürd* (← Per. *gūḡird*) ‘sulphur’ (Ata 1997: 406) and Trk. **(h)aṅ(g)ürt* ‘ruddy goose; a water bird’ (TMEN II No. 563), respectively. In all these cases, the final *-t* or *-tV* must have been perceived as the Proto-Khitano-Mongolic plural suffix **+(V)d* and elided. The same explanation was also made by Doerfer (TMEN III: 58; KhM: 304): He considers Mo. *sūn* as “a reconstructed singular” asserting that the Turkic **sūt* was regarded as a plural form in Mongolic.

A similar ending (or perhaps a suffix) as found in **bonatī* is also found in PPM **ar(V)tī* ‘cypress’ > PM **arčī* ~ **arča* (TMEN II No. 448; MT: 75; N: 272). Instead of being a direct loanword from PT **ärtuč* ‘cypress’ (EDPT: 204), PPM **ar(V)tī* might only be sharing the same base, namely **ar(V)*, with its Turkic cognate.

¹² **mōyīn*, which is attested in Yakut as *моһоһон* ~ *мөһоһон* (< **mo/ōyīn+agan*) ‘blackcurrant’ (Böhtlingk 1851: 149a; Pekarskij 1958–1959 II: 1582). The same sound correspondence of the Turkic *-n* to the Mongolic *-l* is also attested in WM *kögöl* ‘the sloe tree, blackthorn, *Prunus spinosa*’ (MED: 481), which is borrowed from CT **kōkān* ‘*Prunus spinosa*’ (VEWT: 287b). Thus it is probable that the genuine Mongolic **mona* was suppressed by **moyīl* after its borrowing.

¹³ The suffix *+kAi* is also found in insect and animal names such as *biḷjuḡai* ‘any small bird’, *sibauḡai* ‘house sparrow; small bird’ (MED: 105, 694) and **korakai* ‘insect, worm’ (N: 420) where it functions as a diminutive suffix.

¹⁴ This has been borrowed into literary Mongol as *tabilḡu* ‘meadowsweet, *Spiraea* (plant)’ (MED: 761).

¹⁵ The New Uyghur *munda* (Shaw 1878: 225; Nadžip 1968: 721), which is the name of an unidentified plant, might be suspected to be a loanword from the Pre-Proto-Mongolic or Para-Mongolic **bontī* or **montī*. Berbercan (2012: 49) hesitantly identifies *munda* with ‘bir tür ot, lüffāh’.

The only other plant name phonetically similar to *ποντικός* is the Ossetian *mīrtkæ* ~ *murkʼæ* ‘guelder rose, *Viburnum opulus*’, consisting of the elements *mur* (~ *mar*) and *-tki* (~ *-tka* ~ *-ski* ~ *-ska*) according to Abaev (1973: 141). If it goes back to an Alanian form such as **mortka* or **bortka*¹⁶, it might be considered as another candidate for the origin of the Argippaeian *ποντικός*. For the rest, neither Turkic nor any other Central Asian language offers a plant name which can be taken into consideration as a cognate. In summary, the history of the word can be shown as follows: **bonatī* (~ **bonatī+ko* > **bonīko* → *ποντικός*) > (reanalysis) **bona* > **mona* (→ Ma. **muna+ri*) > Mo. **mona+sun*.

4. On the Ethnonym and Identity of the Argippaei

The ethnonym occurs in Herodotus only once as Ἀργιππᾶιοι in 4, 23⁵ (Powell 1938: 44). Tomaschek (1889: 62–63) identifies the original form of the word as Ἀργιππᾶιοι, which is simply a conjectural form extrapolated from the textual variants, and sees in it **arghin* ‘würdig, angesehen’ and Zend *paya* ‘Weide, Trift’ or *pada* ‘Standort, Gebiet, Landstrich’. Similarly to Tomaschek, Marquart (1905: 89–90) sets the original form of the word as Ἀργιππᾶιοι and analyzes it as a compound of the Scythian **argind* (> **argim*) ‘protector, protective’ and **pahaja* ‘pathway’.

Herzfeld (1947: 731) radically equates Ἀργιππᾶιοι with Ἀριμασποῖ and proposes for both ethnonyms an Iranian origin, namely *Argamššavya*, ‘people of Argimpasa’, *Argimpasa* (Ἀργίμπασα) being a Scythian goddess mentioned by Herodotus (4, 59²) whose name, according to Herzfeld, is composed of the words *argant* ‘protector’ and *pasu* ‘cattle’, which is obviously partly inspired by Marquart’s etymology. Although Phillips (1960: 125) agrees with Herzfeld in that Ἀργιππᾶιοι is related to the goddess’ name *Argimpasa*, he objects to his equation of ‘Arimaspi’ and ‘Argippaei’ as “there seems to be no reason for accepting them as dialectal variants”.

Haussig (1979: 129) regards the ethnonym Argippaei as composed of *Argu* (tribal name) and the Persian *paya* ‘pasture’ (in the original text ‘otlak’), probably inspired by Tomaschek for the second part. Despite the time interval of over a millennium between Herodotus and the Old Turkic sources, Haussig unhesitatingly identifies the Argippaei with the Turkic tribe *Argu* who are reported to have inhabited the country between ʾTirāz and Balāsāgūn by Kāšgarī.

Beside the Dīwān Luġāt at-Turk, the ethnonym and the toponym *Argu* ~ *Arugu* occurs in a Manichaean Old Uyğur text as well. The phrases in T II D 171 are quite striking: *ymä ögütmiš alkatmiš č(ä)r(i)g türk uluṣ argu t(a)las kögüz içintä* ‘the praised and blessed warlike (?) Turkic tribe Argu in the breast of Talas’¹⁷; *ymä yokaru kodī ilgärü kerü atī eštilmiš ymä küsi sorulmiš kutlug uluṣ y(a)rašlag altun arugu uluṣ* ‘the sacred tribe, the peaceful golden Arugu tribe whose name is heard and whose fame is spread above and below, in the East and West’; *ymä [a]ltun argu*

16 Note the element **bwru* in *gila-buru* ~ *gila-boru*, the Turkish name for ‘*Viburnum opulus*’.

17 The translation may also be given as follows: ‘the praised and blessed warlike (?) Turkic tribe in the breast of Argu Talas’.

[ul]uš ‘And the golden Argu tribe’ (Le Coq 1912: 26–27; UWb: 178).¹⁸ Considering their sacredness and peacefulness, the Argu tribe concurs very well with the Argippaei. The faint and remote memory of the Argippaei might have here been projected onto the Argu tribe. The statement that they were warlike, as expressed by the word *č(ā)r(i)g* in the text, remains, however, open to interpretation. Contrary to EDPT (p. 215b), UWb (p. 178) rejects Kāšgarī’s identification (s.v. *argu* in fol. 76) of the toponym *Argu* with the Old Turkic word *arku* (> *argu*) ‘valley, ravine between two mountains’ (UWb: 199). The original form of the latter appears to be *arku* as attested in Old Uyğur, which secondarily changed to *argu* and has become homophonous with the former in Qarakhanid Turkic.

According to Kāšgarī (fol. 24 D, 25 D), Arğū was a bilingual population who had a slurring in their speech (Dankoff-Kelly 1982–1985: I, 83–84). Their second language seems to have been Sogdian. Mainly based on the linguistic evidence, Doerfer (KhM: 171–174) asserts that Arğū were Turkicized Sogdians and the ancestors of the modern Khaladj. Since the ethnonyms can easily be adopted without any linguistic and cultural contact, the Turkic-speaking Arğū may have adopted their ethnonym from the Mongolic-speaking Argu that were the Argippaei. It is difficult to determine whether *Argu* was originally an ethnonym or a toponym. I prefer considering it as an ethnonym which then came to be used as the designation of the territory that this ethnic group had occupied.

The original form of Ἀργιππαιοί is likely to be **Argu+pa*, or perhaps **Argi+pa*, a suffixed form of the ethnonym and toponym *Argu*. Similarly, the ethnonym 鮮卑 *Xiānbēi* with the transcription variants 西卑 *Xībēi*¹⁹ and 師比 *Shībī*²⁰ (Toh 2005: 10), which is reconstructed for Old Chinese as **S[a]rpe* by Baxter-Sagart (2014: 3, 121)²¹, may be analyzed as composed of a base **S[a]r* and a suffix **+pe*. Toh (2005: 12) tentatively concludes that 鮮卑 might have represented a foreign “*Šār+pi*”. It is indeed possible that OC **S[a]rpe* represented a foreign **Šerpe* seeing that the tribal name 室韋 *Shìwéi*²², which might be a later transcription of ‘*Xiānbēi*’, points to an original *Širwe* or *Šerwe*.²³ Nonetheless, *Širwe* might have developed from **Serpe* with the secondary palatalization of the sibilant: **Serpe* > **Sirbe* > *Širwe*. The assumed base **Ser* of **Serpe* immediately reminds of the Old Turkic <*s₂Ir₂*> (which can be read *Sir*, *Ser* or even *Šer*) attested in the Tuñuquq (11, 60, 61, 62) and Bilgä Qaghan (E1) inscriptions. Considering its occurrence as *altī sir* in the

18 DTS (p. 51) gives the occurrences as follows: *Argu Talas* ‘odno iz nazvanij goroda Talasa’; *Altun Argu Uluš* ‘odno iz nazvanij goroda Talas’.

19 OC **S-n’or-pe* (Baxter-Sagart 2014: 3, 117); LH *sei/sen-pie*, OCM **sâi/snâi-pe* (Schuessler 2007: 158, 522).

20 OC **Srij-C.pij?* (Baxter-Sagart 2014: 4, 99); LH *ši-pi*, OCM *sri-pi?* (Schuessler 2007: 162, 461).

21 Also cf. OCM **san-pe* (Schuessler 2007: 158, 528).

22 MC *syit-hjwij* (Baxter-Sagart 2014: 101, 114); EMC *cit-wuj* (Pulleyblank 1991: 285, 320); MC *šjet-jwei*, LH *šit-wui*, ONW *šit-*, BTD *-ve* (Schuessler 2007: 466; Schuessler 2009: 292).

23 It is reconstructed as **Sirvi* by Toh (2005: 10).

Bilgä Qaghan inscription, it is almost certain that it is not an adjective but a tribal name (Rybatzki 1997: 79–82). *Türk Sir/Ser Bodun*, the phrase in which the word occurs in the Tuñuquq inscription, must have thus signified ‘the Türk and the Sir people’. Pulleyblank (1990: 21) identifies the 薪犁 Xīn-lí and 薛 Xuē of the Chinese sources with the <s₂Ir₂> of the Old Turkic inscriptions. If this identification is correct, the accurate reading of <s₂Ir₂> is likely to be *Ser* as the Middle Chinese and the Middle Tang readings of 薛 Xuē are *sjät* (Schuessler 2009: 232) and *ser* (cf. Sino-Korean reading 설 *seol*), respectively. The Later Han Chinese reading of 薪犁 Xīn-lí, however, points towards *Sin-li* (Schuessler 2009: 322), which rather stands for **Sir* with /i/ in the first syllable. If the Old Turkic tribal name *Ser* and the **Ser* of the Xiānbēi are identical, +*pA* can be taken to be a suffix for ethnonyms.²⁴ The same suffix appears to be hidden in the self-designation of the Naimans, namely **ñambaGa* ~ **ñambaGan* (Shimunek 2007: 12). In summary, I conclude that Ἀργυπαῖοι stands for **ArgVpa* and that it is composed of the ethnonym *Argu* and the suffix +*pA*.

5. On the Ethnonym of the Arimaspians

The ethnonym occurs in Herodotus as Ἀριμασπιοί in 3, 116¹; 4, 13^{1,2}, 27 and as Ἀριμάσπεα in 4, 14³ (Powell 1938: 45). The most important passage referring to the Arimaspians in *The Histories* is given below.

[27] Anyway, we know about the Issedones too, but for information about what lies to the north of them, we have to rely on their say-so. So it is thanks to the Issedones that we hear of the race of one-eyed men living there, and also about the gold-guarding griffins. When the Scythians talk about these one-eyed men and the griffins they are only repeating what they heard from the Issedones, and then the rest of us believe it and call them, Scythian-style, Arimaspians, because the Scythian words for ‘one’ and ‘eye’ are *arima* and *spou* (Herodotus 1998: 244).

Here, I will not deal with the Arimaspians themselves, but only with their designation, which I suppose has its origins in the language of the Argippaei and not in that of the Scythians. Herodotus explicitly states that the word means ‘one-eyed’ in Scythian and it is composed of ἄριμα ‘one’ and σποῦ ‘eye’ (Powell 1938: 45, 336). Tomaschek (RE II/1: 827) considers the name of the Arimaspians to be of Iranian origin and translates it as ‘Besitzer von wilden, von Steppenrossen’, which Laufer (1908: 452) deems to be unintelligible. Müllenhoff (1892: 105–106) first proposes to analyze the word as composed of **arima* (= μόνος) and *ερας* (= *spak*) but then he

24 Golden (1992: 69) argues that the ending +*pA* (according to him +*bī*) should be compared with the +*bī* of the ethnonym *Tatabī* in the Old Turkic sources. This tribal name, which can also be read *Tatbī*, considering the Tibetan *Dad pyi*, is likely to be related to the tribal name *Tatar* attested both in the Old Turkic and Middle Mongol sources (Rybatzki 2011: 371) but less likely to be related to the Turkic word *tat* (EDPT: 449).

sets aside the meaning given by Herodotus and claims that it is nothing but a compound of *airayma* ‘obedient’ and *açpa* / *açp* ‘horse, steed’. The compound accordingly signifies ‘having obedient horses’. Marquart (1905: 92, 241) regards the ethnonym as Scythian and considers it to be a compound of the Scythian words **arima* ‘einsam’ and **spohú* (< *spas-ú* < *spas-* ‘schauen, bewachen’). Hinge (2005: 90n.) criticises Marquart’s etymology and rightfully adds that ‘Alleinspäher’ is not identical with ‘Einäugiger’. Laufer (1908: 452) is the first to point out the similarity between the Mongolic word *eremdeg* ‘one-eyed’ (which, according to him, undoubtedly derives back to *erem*) and Ἀριμασποί by stressing the unlikelihood of a mere coincidence. Schaefer (1934: 16–19), who deals with the word σποῦ ‘eye’, relates it to the Manichaean title *ispasay* and Old Persian **spaθaka-* ‘Aufseher’, which is criticized by Henning (1939: 240–241).

Grousset (1941: 37n.), in a personal communication with M. Benveniste, reconstructs the original form of the ethnonym as *Ariamaspa*, signifying ‘amis des chevaux’. Herzfeld (1947: 731) proposes an original Iranian form *Argamšavya*, ‘people of Argimpasa’, for Ἀριμασποί, which he considers to be identical with Ἀργιπταῖοι as mentioned above. Phillips (1955: 173–174) rightfully states that the meaning ‘one-eyed’ given by Herodotus cannot be dismissed so easily. Quoting Laufer (1908), he refers to the Mongolic word *eremdeg* for the etymology. He considers *Arimaspea* to be a compound of the Mongolic **erem* ‘one-eyed’ and the Iranian *aspa* ‘horse’, signifying ‘one-eyed horsemen’, which seems far-fetched with regard to the second part. Alemany (1999: 49n.) classifies all the hitherto etymological explanations for the ethnonym under three categories.

Another etymology was recently offered by Hinge (2005: 93). He proposes that the ethnonym may reflect an Iranian form **Arjat-aspa-* ‘der mit Pferden wert ist’. In the electronic version of his paper²⁵, however, he offers another etymology, namely **raiwaqs* / *raiwantah aspān* ‘rich of horses’ (cf. Young Avestan *raēva*, *raēvant* ‘rich’, Old Indic *revant*, Ossetian *riwæ* ‘richness’ and *aspa* ‘horse’). Taking as a starting point Laufer’s suggestion, I will offer a new etymology completely based on Mongolic.²⁶

The Mongolic word *eremdeg* ~ *eremdek*, which Laufer (1908) refers to, is attested in Middle Mongol, Written Mongol and some modern Mongolic languages: SH (75) *eremdek* ‘schäbig, schlecht’ (Haenisch 1962: 45)²⁷, WM *eremdeg* ‘odnoglazyj, krivoj’ (Kowalewski 1844–1849: I: 250a), *eremdeg* ‘one-eyed’ (Boberg 1954: 116), *eremdeg* ‘invalid, cripple; maimed, crippled’ (MED: 322); Khal. *eremdeg* ‘kaleka; iskalečennyj, povreždennyj’ (Luvsandэндэв 1957: 680); Kalm. *ermdəg* ‘körperliches Gebrechen’, *ermdəg nüttē* ‘mit irgendeinem Fehler an den

25 <http://herodot.glossa.dk/arimasp.html> (last access: June 23, 2016).

26 Before going on with the etymological discussion, it is to be reminded that in the genealogy of Činggis Qa’an right at the beginning of the *Secret History* a certain Du’a Soqor, the son of Toroqoljin Bayan, appears who “had a single eye in the middle of his forehead” (Mo. *manglai dumda qačča nidütü*).

27 In the SH, the word is attested in a binomial with *jemdek*.

Augen' (Ramstedt 1935: 126), Kalm. *ermdg* 'urodstvo, nedostatok' (KRS: 703); Bur. *eremdeg* 'urodstvo; urod, vyrodok' (Čeremisov 1951: 739); Oir. (Xinjiang) *eremdeg* 'nedostatok, izjan, defect' (Todaeva 2001: 478). As can be seen above, the meaning 'one-eyed' is only given by Kowalewski and Boberg. The original meaning of the word is probably 'maimed, crippled' and its base is not attested. However, as already stated by Laufer, it may very well be **erem*. The habitive participle *-dAg*, which is the Mongolic cognate of the Turkic perfect participle *-dOk* (Erdal 2004: 293–296), is also used to form nouns and adjectives (Poppe 1987: 273) such as WM *sirdeg* 'saddlepad' from *siri-* 'to stitch', WM *silideg* 'exquisite, choice, select' from *sili-* 'to choose', Mgr. *furgudog* 'timid', Ord. *urguudek* from **hürgü-* 'to be startled, frightened' and SH *kökideg* 'fearful' from *köki-* 'to be frightened'.

An older formation with *-dAg* can be found in Mo. *temdeg* 'mark, sign'²⁸, which is attested in the *Secret History* and in Written Mongol. It is derived from the verbal base **temV-*, which surfaces in Khitan as 𐰇𐰏𐰪 < t.em > 'to enfeoff, to bestow [land], to bestow a title, to confer (a title); to appoint' (Kane 2009: 100–101; Wu Yingzhe-Janhun 2010: 80–81, 98, 189). Another transparent word formed with *-dAg* is PM **mokudag* 'blunt, dull' < **moku-* 'to become blunt' (N: 445). SH *jemdeg* 'schäbig, schlecht, Abfall' (Haenisch 1962: 88), which occurs in a binomial with *eremdeg*, also exhibits a similar formation. Its unattested base **jem(V)-* might be the cognate of the unattested base **yām(i)-* of CT *yemir-* ~ *yāmür-* 'to smash, to shatter, to uproot' and Chuv. *šēmēr-* 'razbit'; *razrušat*, *lomat*; *razorjat*' (EDPT: 937; VEWT: 197; ÈSTJa IV: 183–184; Fedotov 1996, II: 108).

If the adjective *eremdeg* is formed with *-dAg* as well, its base can be taken to be **erem-*. However, there are no disyllabic Mongolic verbs ending in *m-*. Thus I suppose that a syncope has occurred in the word *eremdeg* and that the verbal base must have had the form **eremV-*. The actual form of **eremV-* might be **eremi-* or **ereme-* 'to be crippled, to be maimed' going back to an adjective **erem*. The formative *+i-* is attested in verbs such as WM *eseni-* 'to recuperate' and *ösi-* 'to hate, feel vengeful', which are derived from the nouns *esen* and *ös*, respectively. The same formative also surfaces as 𐰇𐰏𐰪 in the Khitan verb 𐰇𐰏𐰪𐰇𐰏𐰪 < s.em.ii > 'to die of a fatal illness' derived from 𐰇𐰏𐰪 < s.em > 'sick, ill, contract disease' (Kane 2009: 92, 116). The formative *+A-* occurs in verbs such as SH *qojida-* 'to be late', *ča'ura-* 'to go on a campaign' (Kempf 2009: 138) and WM *juta-* 'to suffer hunger or poverty' (MED: 1081). It cannot be dismissed that the base might have been **erim* and that *eremdeg* is the result of a secondary assimilation of the vowel *i* to the vowel in the neighboring syllable as Poppe (1963) argues for other instances: **erim+i/e-deg* > **erimdeg* > *eremdeg*.

If the first part of the word, namely 𐰇𐰏𐰪, is accepted to stand for PPM **erim* 'maimed', the second part *-aσtoí* is still left to be explained. I posit that the second part contains the Pre-Proto-Mongolic word for 'eye' and the possessive adjectival

28 The Manchu *temgetü* 'sign, signal, mark, brand, badge, stamp, emblem' (Norman 1978: 276), which is the cognate of the Mongolic *temdeg*, must be the result of metathesis.

suffix. First, we should revisit the reconstruction of the Pre-Proto-Mongolic form of the word for ‘eye’. The Proto-Mongolic word for ‘eye’ is **nidün* (N: 459). However, as both Janhunen (1996: 211) and Nugteren (N: 459) argue, *+dUn* may be a (collective?) suffix as seen in **emüdü* ‘trousers’ (N: 329), of which the base is borrowed from the Turkic **ām* < **jēmā* ‘trousers’ (KhM: 292; WCh: 137), and in *modun* ‘tree, wood’ (Janhunen 1996: 210; N: 444–445). In this case, the Pre-Proto-Mongolic form can be reconstructed as **ni* with a high degree of certainty.²⁹ The evidence from Khitan and other Para-Mongolic languages which we need to reconstruct older forms of **ni* is unfortunately lacking. Nevertheless, we know, thanks to the Khitan language, that some words have been attached with a prosthetic *n-* in Pre-Proto-Mongolic. The Khitan cognate of the Proto-Mongolic **nere* ‘name’ (N: 455) is 𐰽𐰺𐰍 / 𐰽𐰺𐰍 [ərə] or [ir] ‘name, title’ (Shimunek 2007: 75; Wu Yingzhe-Janhunen 2010: 55; Janhunen 2012: 127; Shimunek 2014: 114) < PKM **ere*.³⁰ If a prosthetic *n-* is also present in the Pre-Proto-Mongolic **ni* ‘eye’, it hypothetically goes back to the Proto-Khitano-Mongolic **i* ‘eye’. If this reconstruction is accepted, the Proto-Tungusic **iāsa* ‘eye’ (Benzing 1956: 25, 70; Georg 1999/2000: 152) and the Pre-Proto-Tungusic **iā*³¹ ‘eye’ (< **i+xa*³²) can easily be related to PKM **i*.³³

Next, I will deal with the reconstruction of the earliest form of the Common Mongolic possessive adjectival suffix **+tA(y)i* (Poppe 1987: 82–83; Janhunen 2003: 11). As the plural form of **tA(y)i* was *+tAn* in Middle and Written Mongol (Poppe 1987: 176, 204), *+(y)i* can undoubtedly be identified as a suffix with an unspecified function. Its reconstruction as **+gl* or **+pl* for Pre-Proto-Mongolic is equally possible. I will discuss it further below and deal with **+tA* first. Nonetheless, **+tA*

29 Janhunen (1996: 211–212) attempts to relate *nilbusun* ‘tears, mucus, spittle’ to **ni* ‘eye(s)’ suggesting that *nilbusun* contains the elements ‘eye’ + ‘water’ (**nil+usu/n*). However, the noun **nilbusun* is clearly derived from **nilbu-* ‘to spit’ (N: 457). The verb **nilbu-* itself comes from **ni* or more likely from **nil*, which is also the base of *nisun* ‘snot, nasal mucus’ (N: 458) and perhaps of *nīy-* ‘to blow one’s nose’ (N: 459). On the other hand, Georg (2003: 443) asserts that Mo. *ni-gur* ‘face’ is clearly etymologically related to *nidün*. Nugteren (N: 459) reconstructs the word in question as **niür* (~ **niür*) ‘face’, which would correspond to **niyür* (~ **niyür*) in my notation. I disagree with Georg since I am not certain if we can morphologically analyse the word as **ni+yur*. Even if we could, it would be not easy to relate **ni* ‘eye’ and **ni*, both from the phonetic and semantic aspect.

30 The Khitan word is borrowed into Middle Korean as 일흠 *ilhom* ‘name’ (Shimunek 2007: 75) and perhaps into Tangut as *jī²rjir²* (Jacques 2010: 164).

31 Cf. Nanai *yārsi-* ‘rassmatrivat’, *razgljadyvat*; ‘proverjat’ (Onenko 1980: 544) < PPTg. **iā* ‘eye’.

32 The idea that the diphthong in Tungusic could be of a contractive origin is taken from Janhunen (1996: 211). Little is known about how the Proto-Tungusic **x* acted in the intervocalic position. Only two instances of medial **x* are given by Benzing (1956: 42) but in both instances it occurs before the vowel /i/. Cincius (1949: 251) gives the intervocalic **x* (in his notation **kx^h*) with a question mark and indicates its non-occurrence in the table.

33 As possible cognates, it might be referred to Muh. *išār-* ‘gözetmek’ (Battal 1934: 34) and Chuv. (dial.) *isker-* ‘nabljudat’, *sledit’* (izdali) (ČRS: 117), both of which seem to go back to **is+gār-*, and PTg. **iče-* ‘to see’ (Benzing 1956: 22; SSTJa I: 334) in this context.

might not be the oldest form of the suffix. I suspect that it underwent the Pre-Proto-Mongolic sporadic sound change $*s > t$, of which rare instances are given beneath:

1. The most crucial pieces of evidence for a sound change $*s > t$ in Pre-Proto-Mongolic come from the Turkic loanwords in Mongolic. Mo. **türi-* ‘to drag; to push’ (N: 527)³⁴ points towards a sound change of the onset $*s-$ $> t-$ in Pre-Proto-Mongolic assuming that it is a cognate of the Old and Middle Turkic *sürü-* $\sim$ *sürä-* ($>$ *sürü-*) ‘to drag, haul’³⁵. Another clear case of the sound change $*s > t$, this time in medial position, can be shown by means of PM **itege-* ‘to believe, trust’ (N: 377), which is clearly a cognate of an unattested derivation from the base of Trk. *išan-* ‘to trust, believe in, rely on’ (EDPT: 264).³⁶ The cognate pair of Mo. **budaŋ* ‘fog, mist’ (N: 289) and OT *būs* ‘mist, fog’ (EDPT: 370) exhibits a sound change of the medial $-s-$ $> -t-$ and a subsequent voicing of $-t-$ ³⁷ as well.
2. The second piece of evidence is a Xiongnu loanword in Mongolic. PM **tosun* and PPM **to* ‘fat, oil, butter’ (N: 523) seem to be related to the assumed Xiongnu loanword in Han Chinese 酥 *sū* **so*³⁸ ‘butter’ (Pulleyblank 1962: 254), which Pulleyblank himself compares with the Ket *so* ‘aus Fischdärmen gekochtes Fett’ recorded by Donner (1955: 83). The Xiongnu **so* (or a similar form) must have entered into Xianbei as well and have changed there to **to* having undergone the sound change of the onset $*s-$ $> t-$.
3. The third sources of information are the Mongolic loanwords in Jurchen and Manchu. The loanwords given below exhibit a correspondence of the Jurchen-Manchu *s-* and the Mongolic *t-*.
 - i. Jur. *seje* ‘wagon’ (Kiyose 1977: 111), Ma. *sejen* ‘wagon, cart, vehicle’ (Norman 1978: 236); Mo. **tergen* ‘cart’ (MT: 104; N: 519).

34 It is attested as *türi-* $\sim$ *türe-* ‘to drag, haul, tug; to push forward; to bully, push around’ in Written Mongol (MED: 855) and as *turi-* ‘stoßen, schieben’ in the SH (Haenisch 1962: 155).

35 Several times attested as *süri-* $\sim$ *sürä-* $\sim$ *sürü-* in Khwarezm Turkic sources. Its earliest attestation, however, appears to be *süri-* in a Qarakhanid Quran translation: (TĪEM 73 125v/6) *kāmišti taxtalarni tut(t)i äčisiniñ sačini süriyür öziñä* (Ünlü 2012: 700).

36 It is difficult to explain the suffix $-gA-$ ($< *kA-$) attached to the base **ite-* from the Mongolic aspect. Therefore, I consider Mo. *itege-* as a borrowing from an unattested Turkic form **iśä-k-* similar to Mo. **tarka-* ‘to scatter, spread, be dispersed’ (N 513) $\leftarrow$ OT *tar-ık-* ‘to disperse (intr.), to be driven away, go away’ (OTWF: 648) and Mo. *julğa-* ‘to pull out, to pluck’ (MED: 1078) $\leftarrow$ OT *yul-(u)k-* ‘to pluck (out)’ (EDPT: 924).

37 Cf. PPM **bi+ta* ‘I and you’ $>$ PM *bida* (Janhunen 2003: 19), WM *bidasun* $\sim$ *baitasun* ($\leftarrow$ Trk. *baytal*) and the other examples given by Janhunen (2013: 215) who states that “in all these cases, the original segment seems to have been the strong $*r$ ”. For the suffix $+Aŋ$, cf. WM *da-lang* ‘nape of the neck (of animals); withers (of a horse)’ (MED: 224) $\leftarrow$ Trk. *yāl* ‘a horse’s mane, the place where the mane grows’ (EDPT: 916).

38 It is reconstructed as *so* for Early Middle Chinese by Pulleyblank (1991: 294).

- ii. Ma. *sefere* ‘a handful, a bundle’, *sefere-* ‘to take a handful, to grab with the hand’ (Norman 1978: 235); Mo. **teberi-* ‘to embrace’ (N: 515), *teberi* ‘embrace, clasp, armful’ (MED: 790).³⁹
- iii. Ma. *sideri* ‘hobbling device, foot fetters, a hobble for animals; anklet’, Ma. *sidere-* ‘to hobble, to tie up, to trip, to encumber’ (Norman 1978: 241); Mo. **čidör* (< **tidör*) ‘horse’s hobble; shackles’ (N: 304). The Dagur form *šidər* (Enkhbat 1984: 236) is an unexpected and irregular reflex and may be a relic of the archaic **sidör*, which is likely to be the source of Ma. *sideri*. However, it is very likely that this sound change has occurred not on the Mongolic, but on the Jurchenic (Jurchen-Manchu) side as Norman (1977) argues.
4. The Pre-Proto-Mongolic exhibits incongruity among other Altaic languages when it comes to the second-person singular pronouns: PPM **tī* or **ti* (Janhunen 2003: 18); PT **sā* or **si* (Erdal 2004: 196n.); PTg. **si* (Benzing 1956: 108). Whereas the Proto-Turkic and Proto-Tungusic 2sg pronouns are reconstructed with the onset **s*, the Pre-Proto-Mongolic pronoun points towards an onset **t*. It is possible that PPM **tī* or **ti* comes from an earlier form **sī* or **si*. Janhunen (2013: 223) states that “the primary alternation between **t* (in Mongolic and Tungusic) and **s* (in Turkic and Tungusic) in the second-person items remains unexplained”. The Pre-Proto-Mongolic (sporadic) sound change *s > t* might be a possible explanation for this discrepancy when considered with other instances.
5. The most solid piece of evidence for this sound change comes from Tabgač. The Tabgač 可孫 *kēsūn* **kasun*⁴⁰ ‘title of the Tabgač Empress’ (Boodberg 1936: 169; Bazin 1950: 305–306), which is certainly a cognate of the Turkic **kātun*⁴¹ (EDPT 602) and the Mongolic **katun* ‘empress; wife; woman’ (N: 405), exhibits an unexpected *-s-* in place of the more common *-t-*. The same word is attested as 可尊 *kězūn*⁴² **katsun* (**kaθun?* **kačun?*) in the language of the Tuyuhun (Boodberg 1936: 170; Bazin 1950: 306; MT: 162)⁴³ and perhaps as 尔 [333] in Khitan (Kane 2009: 75, 112) of which the reading is uncertain.

Evidently, this word signifying ‘queen, empress’ is closely related to its masculine counterparts *kan* ‘khan’ and *kagan* ‘qaghan’ and contains a certain feminine gender suffix with varying forms in *+tun* ~ *+sun* ~ *+tsun*. Doerfer (TMEN III:136; MT: 161) considers the primary form of this suffix to be “*+tun*” and attributes it to the language of the Xianbei whereas Vovin (2007a: 184; 2011a: 2) reckons it to be “*+tu*” and sees its origin in the language of the Ruan-ruan.

39 Mo. **teberi-* is also borrowed into Manchu as *tebeliye-* ‘to hug, to embrace, to hold in the arms; to adopt a child’ (Norman 1978: 274).

40 Cf. LH *k^hai-suən*, ONW *k^ha-son* (Schuessler 2007: 275, 486; Schuessler 2009: 210, 339).

41 The earlier form of the title in Turkic was probably **kayatum*, cf. the Chinese transcriptions 可敦 *kēdūn* and 可賀敦 *kēhèdūn* (Bazin 1950: 306; Skaff 2012: 394).

42 Cf. LH *k^hai-tsuən*, ONW *k^ha-tson* (Schuessler 2007: 275, 637).

43 Doerfer (MT: 162) notes that either the Tabgač or the Tuyuhun must have borrowed the word from the other.

In contrast to common opinion, the Tabgač *+sun* may be the primary form of the suffix whereas the Ruan-ruan *+tun* is borrowed from a Para-Mongolic language which had already undergone the sound change *-s- > -t-*, at least in the case of the suffix *+sUn*.⁴⁴ This Para-Mongolic language is likely to be Xianbei since *+tun* is attested in the Xianbei word 阿摩敦 *āmódūn* **amatun*⁴⁵ ‘mother’ (Boodberg 1936: 170; MT: 161).⁴⁶ A sound change *-t- > -s-*, which can be held responsible for the aberrant *+sun*, is otherwise not attested in Tabgač, as Doerfer (TMEN III: 140) also argues. The Tabgač words *pürtükčīn*, *bitikčīn* and *kityaičīn* (*kityečīn*?) (Vovin 2007: 194–197) retain the voiceless dental consonant *t* in the preconsonantal, postconsonantal and intervocalic positions. Another case where Xianbei seems to be more innovative than Tabgač is the palatalization of *t* and *d* before the high unrounded vowels. In Xianbei, we find PPM **gutīn* ‘thirty’ as **yočīn* (Vovin 2007: 194) whereas the Tabgač words *bitikčīn* and *modi* (Vovin 2007: 196–197) do not show any trace of palatalization.

I am of the opinion that the Mongolic feminine suffixes *+jin* and *+gčīn* might have developed from a secondary grammaticalisation of PPM **čīn* ‘woman’, which itself is likely to be a loanword from the rarely attested Turkic word **čīn* ‘woman, wife’. It has survived as *čīnay* ‘wife’ in Codex Cumanicus (Kuun 1880: 114), as *čīn* in Saryg Uyğur (Nugteren-Roos 1996: 42) and perhaps as *šin* ‘man, person’ in Chuvash.⁴⁷ Thus it is possible that *+sun* (> *+tun*) had similarly developed from a word **so* or **su* signifying ‘woman, wife’. The Xiongnu language is the most probable source. However, I was not able to find a similar Xiongnu word recorded in the Chinese sources.⁴⁸ Nevertheless, the existence of a Chinese loanword in Xiongnu seems quite likely. The Chinese 嫂 *sǎo* ‘elder brother’s wife’⁴⁹ may have been borrowed into Xiongnu as **so* or **su* with the widened meaning ‘wife (of an elder male relative)’. It must have entered from Xiongnu into Xianbei where the Mongolic *+n* was suffixed to it so that it became **son* or **sun*.⁵⁰ Either before or after becom-

44 Some sound changes might not be universal but restricted to a suffix, cf. PM *+AčA > CM +AsAA* (Janhunen 2003: 15), although *č* is preserved as such in CM.

45 Cf. LH ?-mai-tuan, ONW ?a-ma-ton (Schuessler 2007: 149, 220, 389).

46 Note that the Tabgač word occurs in 南齊書 *Nan Qi Shu* (completed in 537) and the Xianbei word occurs in 周書 *Zhou Shu* (completed in 636) of *Twenty-Four Histories*.

47 There are few other cases where the Chuvash *ī* corresponds to the Common Turkic **ī* and **ĩ* (Ceylan 1997: 165). Also note Chuv. *kěšēn šīn* ‘molodaja, novobračnaja’, *yivār šīn* ‘beremen-naja’ (ČRS: 432). Other etymological attempts include the Cheremiss *yeŋ* (by M. Adamović), Persian *jān* (by N. Poppe), OT *tīn* (by N. Poppe), OT *yalhuk* (by G. Doerfer) and OT *yīn* (by E. Ceylan) (Ceylan 1997: 49–50).

48 The Xiongnu word for ‘shan-yu’s wife’ is reconstructed **alte* / **elte* by Vovin (2003: 392) as a cognate of PY **ʔal/r’it* ‘wife’. However, this reconstruction is also reminiscent of the Middle Turkic *älti* ~ *eltü* ~ *ilti* ‘lady’, which survives as *elti* in Turkish, Azeri, Turkmen, Uzbek and Qaraqalpaq (Li 1999: 304–305).

49 LH *sou*^B, OCM **sū*? (Schuessler 2009: 154).

50 The Yukagir *songa* (< **songa* < **son+qə* ?) ‘maidservant’ (Nikolaeva 2006: 414) can be referred to as a possible cognate.

ing a suffix, it underwent the sound change $s > t$ and has become $*(+)\text{tun}$ in Xianbei, but in Tabgač it has been retained as $*+\text{sun}$.

It must be noted here that $+\text{sun} \sim +\text{tun}$, unlike the Mongolic $+\text{j}\dot{\text{in}}$ and $+\text{g}\dot{\text{c}}\text{in}$, was probably not a general feminine suffix. It was only added to nouns denoting human beings such as $*\text{ama}$ ‘father’⁵¹, and kan ‘khan’. The sound change of $s > t$ in Xianbei may have been triggered by the language of the Xiongnu which seems to have undergone a similar change if the Xiongnu gloss 馱驪 *juétí* LH *kuet-dei* (Schuessler 2007: 326) $*\text{kuti}$ or $*\text{kute}$ ‘horse’ is accepted to be a cognate of PY $*\text{ku}^2\text{s}$ ‘horse’ (Vovin 2000: 91). On the other hand, the sound change of the medial $-s- > -t-$ in Yakut (Anderson 1998: 14), which even includes the suffixes such as the 3sg possessive suffix $+tA$ ($< \text{GT} +sI$), may be the result of intensive contact with the Pre-Proto-Mongolic or Para-Mongolic languages. Considering the evidence presented above in favor of the Pre-Proto-Mongolic sound change $*s > t$ in word-initial and word-medial position, I see no problem in arguing that the possessive adjectival $*+\text{t}A$ may go back an earlier $*+\text{s}A$.

The possible Para-Mongolic cognates of the Mongolic possessive adjectival suffixes are as follows: According to Boodberg (1936: 171), Bazin (1950: 314–315) and Doerfer (MT: 162), the masculine possessive adjectival suffix $+tU$ already occurs in the Tabgač cognomen 豆盧突 *dòu-lú-tū* $*\text{törötü}$ ($< \text{törö} + \text{tü}$). However, the Middle Chinese reading of 豆盧突 *dòu-lú-tū* is *duwH-lu-dwot/thwot* (Baxter-Sagart 2014: 23, 70, 111)⁵², which can be interpreted as $*\text{duludot}$ or $*\text{durudot}$. The character 突 *dwot/thwot*⁵³ can hardly be identified with the Mongolic suffix $+tU$ since there are more suitable Early Middle Chinese syllables such as *du* and *thu*. Therefore, it is highly unlikely that this cognomen does contain the suffix $+tU$. Talpe’s (2010: 88) identification of the syllable 統 *tōng* in a Khitan gloss with the suffix “-*tun*” is also unjustified. The only proposal to be taken serious comes from Yingzhe-Janhun (2010: 71, 79, 100, 188–189). They suggest identifying the segment 矢 *de* in 关化矢 *ǰi.ri.de* (Xiao Dilu 6, 10, 21 and Yelü Xiangwen 25) with the Mongolic $+tU / +tAi$. However, it may simply be the dative marker as they think it to be in the first place. The phrase 关化矢 𠂇夾化 *ǰi.ri.de x.ui.ri* (Yelü Xiangwen 25), in particular, seems to literally signify ‘to reach at fame’.

The only direct attestation of $*+\text{s}A$ may be found in Khitan. The Khitan word 阿思 / 阿斯 $*\text{as}$ or $*\text{asə}$ ‘spacious, extensive’ (Shimunek 2007: 67; Sun Bojun-Nie Hongyin 2008: 209)⁵⁴, which probably goes back to PKM $*\text{asa}$, seems to contain the suffix $*+\text{s}A$. It formally corresponds to the Turkic $*(h)\dot{\text{a}}\text{n} + \text{lig}$ ‘broad’ derived from

51 The base $*\text{ama}$ is probably the Para-Mongolic cognate of the Mongolic *aba* ~ *abu* ‘father, grandfather’. Also cf. Mo. *eme* ‘woman’ and Jurchen-Manchu *ama* ‘father’ (Kane 1989: 267).

52 Cf. MC *dəu-luo-duət/tuət* (Schuessler 2007: 215, 364, 501).

53 Cf. ONW *dot* (Schuessler 2007: 501).

54 Manchu *asi* ‘very’ and Udeghe *asi* ‘očen’ (Norman 1978: 20; Šnejder 1936: 17; SSTJa I: 54) might be of Khitan origin ($*\text{asə}$) unless they were borrowed from Mo. *asuru* ‘very, very much’ ($\leftarrow$ OT *aśru* ~ *aśuru*), which is very unlikely. Udeghe *asahi* ‘očen’ $< *+\text{asa} + \text{hi}$ (Šnejder 1936: 17) must be of the same origin.

*(h)ān ‘breadth’ (VEWT: 43; KhM: 292). The base of the Khitan word which is *a ‘space, breadth, width’⁵⁵ is also the base of the Proto-Mongolic *ayu ~ *ayui ~ *agui ‘broad, wide, vast, spacious’ (N: 274). The denominal formative +(A)yu(i)⁵⁶ is very rare and can only be found in traces: Mo. *ügeiyüi*, *ügeyü(i)* ‘without’ < *ügei ‘there is not; without; not’ (N: 539); Mo. **sirayu* ‘earth, ground, soil, dust’ (N: 492) < *sira ← BT **siārā* = CT *sāz* ‘marsh, mud’ (VEWT: 406); Mo. **jālayu(i)* ‘young (person)’ (N: 381) < *jala ← BT **jālā* ‘young’ (MT: 127) = CT *yāš*; Mo. **jalkayu* ‘lazy’ (N: 381–382) < *jalka ← BT **jalikā* = GT *yašik* ‘lazy’ (VEWT: 192); WM *namayu* (Khal. *namuu*) ‘low, slanting, gently sloping’ < WM *nam* ‘low’ (MED: 562).⁵⁷

The Tungusic adjectival possessive (or propriative) suffix in *+si, which has yielded Solon +si (Tsumagari 2009: 12–13), Udeghe +xi (Girfanova 2002: 23; Nikolaeva-Tolskaya 2001: 141–145), Nanai +si (Petrova 1967: 58–59) and Oroch +si⁵⁸, might have its origin in the Khitan *+sə.⁵⁹ Similar propriative suffixes are also found in the Selkup +sima and +simil’, which form propriative nouns and adjectives respectively (Helinski 1998: 572). Another +si, which seems to have a similar function, appears in the Proto-Bulgarian inscription of Preslav: αλχαση κυπε *alxa+si küpā* (lit.) ‘armour with rings’ = ‘chainmail’ (Beševliev 1992: 199–204).⁶⁰

Considering the suffix *(y)i contained in PM *+tA(y)i, it is likely to be a marker of feminine gender as Janhunen (2003: 25) suspects it to be since *+tA(y)i was generally used with feminine subjects in the earliest sources. It would surely not be wrong to equate the suffix *(y)i with the second syllable of the Middle Mongol feminine confirmative and resultative markers -liyi ~ -liyi ~ -leyi (-li’i) and -jīyi (-ji’i) (Weiers 1969: 149–159; Rybatzki 2003: 75–76). The second syllables of their masculine counterparts -lA’A ~ -lU’A and -jU’U, on the other hand, may be identi-

55 It is possible, although very hypothetical, that *a or *a(n) may have been borrowed from the Turkic *(h)ān. The correspondence of Mongolic a and Turkic ā / ā̄ and the elision of final n are both not unattested: Mo. *haran*, Khit. 𐰽𐰺𐰠 <p.ar> ‘people’ (Janhunen 2012: 124); PT **pārān* ‘men’ (OT *ārān*). However, the correspondence of Turkic onset *h (<*p) and the Mongolic vowel onset is rare, but not unattested: PM **ere* ‘man’ (N: 331–332); Turkic **hārā* or **hārā* ‘man’ (KhM: 292–293). Either Khaladj *h-* in *(h)ān is of prosthetic and secondary nature or Mo. *a(n) is a younger borrowing from Turkic **hān* and not from the older **pān*.

56 A similar adjective-forming suffix is also found in Old Turkic in the form of +gU: *ädgü*, *enčgü*, *mānigü* (OTWF: 162–164).

57 This denominal formative must be kept apart from the homophonous deverbal formative -yUi as attested in SH *sili’ui* ‘good’ and WM *ariyui* ‘pure’, which are derived from the verbal bases *sili-* and *ari-*, respectively.

58 It occurs as petrified in adjectives such as *jūisi* ‘sour’, *gičisi* ‘cold’, *gotisi* ‘bitter’, *maṇasi* ‘hard, strong’, *xakasi* ~ *xekusi* ‘hot’ (Avrorin-Lebedeva 1978: 174, 184, 202, 243, 250).

59 Cf. Evenki +čī (Bulatova-Grenoble 1999: 15), the function of which is very similar.

60 Although their functions differ considerably, the Proto-Bulgarian +si may well be reckoned as the cognate of the Old Turkic similitive +sIg. This explanation is already given by Tekin (1987: 40). Nonetheless, it is doubtful whether the word-final -g was already elided in Proto-Bulgarian. The Proto-Bulgarian loanwords in Old Church Slavonic such as **bālāg* indicate otherwise.

fied as markers of masculine gender. The vowels *A* and *U* signal the masculine gender whereas the vowel *i* signals the feminine gender (Rybatzki 2003: 75),⁶¹ a situation which finds its resemblance in the Nepali language where the vowels *-o* and *-a* stand for the masculine gender whereas the vowel *-i* stands for the feminine gender.⁶² The question whether these suffixes go back to a set of suffixes with an onset **g-* (**+gA* / **+gU* / **+gI*) or with an onset **p-* (**+pA* / **+pU* / **+pI*) cannot be answered without external evidence which we unfortunately lack. However, a certain grammatical feature may provide us with indirect evidence in favour of the reconstructions **+pA* / **+pU* / **+pI*.

Table 1: Middle Mongol Finite Tense-Aspect Markers

	masculine	feminine
terminative	<i>-bA</i>	<i>-bi</i>
confirmative	<i>-lA 'A ~ -lU 'A</i>	<i>-li 'i</i>
resultative	<i>-jU 'U</i>	<i>-ji 'i</i> (and <i>-ji 'Ai</i>)

The paradigm shown in the table above clearly exhibits the contrast between the one-syllabic terminative markers and two-syllabic confirmative and resultative markers. In my opinion, the markers were originally identical in respect of the number of their syllables and the one-syllabic terminative markers have emerged as a result of haplology. The original paradigm in Pre-Proto-Mongolic can be reconstructed as follows:

Table 2: Pre-Proto-Mongolic Finite Tense-Aspect Markers

	neuter	masculine	feminine
Terminative	<i>*-bA</i> ⁶³	<i>*-bApA</i>	<i>*-bIpI</i>

61 It is noteworthy that both Mongolic feminine suffixes *+gčīn* and *+jin* contain the vowel *i*.

62 Cf. Nepali *choro* 'son' (vocative *chorā*) vs. *chori* 'daughter'; *keṭo* 'boy' vs. *keṭī* 'girl'; *rāmro* 'handsome' vs. *rāmri* 'beautiful' (Acharya 1991: 77–79).

63 PPM **-bA* is a cognate of the Khitan past tense marker **-bən/ń* (Shimunek 2007: 55–56; Kane 2009: 147: 155; Shimunek 2011: 105; Shimunek 2011a: 95–96). Shimunek (2011a: 95–96) suggests a "Proto-Serbi-Mongolic" form **-bAń* asserting that the Khitan suffix is a cognate of the Mongolic finite tense marker **-bA(y)i*.

	neuter	masculine	feminine
Confirmative	*-lU ⁶⁴	*-lUpA	*-llpI
Resultative	*-jU ⁶⁵	*-jUpU	*-jIpI

Here, I assume that the terminative markers **-bApA* > **-bAbA* and **-blpI* > **-blbI* had yielded **-bA* and **-bI* through haplology before the intervocalic *-p-* underwent spirantization. The confirmative markers **-lUpA* / **-llpI* and the resultative markers **-jUpU* / **-jIpI* seem to have evolved regularly over **-lUyA* / **-llyI* and **-jUyU* / **-jlyI* to the attested Middle and Written Mongol forms. If the gender markers were reconstructed as **+gA* / **+gU* / **+gI*, it would not be so easy to explain the one-syllabic terminative markers *-bA* and *-bI*.

As far as we know for now, the gender-specific tense markers reconstructed above are not attested as such in Khitan although the Khitan finite past tense markers do show a gender distinction (Kane 2009: 144). Either they have not been retained in the Para-Mongolic branch or, in more likelihood, the gender markers have started to integrate into the verbal morphology within the Pre-Proto-Mongolic lineage. Still, the gender suffix **+pI* might be hidden in few Khitan nouns signifying female persons: Khit. 圣田伏 <yi.l.ń> = 迺邈免 yilimian ~ 乙林免 yilinmian **yili(m)m'ə* ‘princess consort’ (Kane 2009: 85, 115, 129) < **yilimi*⁶⁶ < **yili+pi* < **yili* ← Turkic **yili* ‘a title’⁶⁷; Khit. 今矣伏 <pu.si.ń> **pušin* ‘lady’ (Kane 2009: 104; Shimunek 2011: 106; Róna-Tas 2016: 125) < **pušimm'ə* < **pušin+pi* < **pušin* ← Chin. 夫人 furen **fužin*.⁶⁸ The sound change of **m' > ń* in Khitan is traceable by an additional lexical item, namely Khit. 捏骨地 **ñaGu(r)di-* ‘to kneel (跪)’ (< **m'a-*

64 PPM **-lU* is a cognate of the Khitan past tense marker **-lən/ń* (Kane 2009: 146–147; Shimunek 2011: 105; Shimunek 2014: 106: 113). Poppe’s (1987: 265) analysis of *-luya* ~ *-luyai* as a compound of the verbal suffix *-l* and the predicative mark **-yai* (*-u-* functioning as a connective vowel) needs reevaluation in light of recent research.

65 PPM **-jU* is a cognate of the Khitan converb marker **-j* / **-Sč* (also used in finite function) (Kane 2009: 153–154; Wu Yingzhe-Janhun 2010: 69; Vovin 2011: 127; Shimunek 2011: 105; Shimunek 2011a: 94–95; Shimunek 2014: 113).

66 In this case, an irregular intervocalic alternation of *p* and *m* is supposed to be involved as described by Janhun 2003: 5–6 for PPM **küpiin* ~ **kümiin* ‘man’ and by Yingzhe-Janhun 2010: 69 for **kepe-* ~ **keme-* ‘to say’. The same alternation is also present in PM **obag* ~ **omag* ‘clan, family’ (N: 467) < **opag* ← Turkic **ōpa* ‘tribe’ (VEWT: 363).

67 It occurs as 伊利 *yī-lì* and 意利 *yì-lì* in the Chinese transcriptions of Bumīn Qaghan’s, Īšbara Qaghan’s and Qimin Qaghan’s regnal titles (Rybatzki 2000: 206–208; Skaff 2012: 116, 117, 390, 399). Khitan also had other titles of Turkic origin such as *irgin* (Kane 2009: 128–129; Sun Bojun-Nie Hongyin 2008: 213) ← OT *irkin* (EDPT: 225).

68 Shimunek (2011: 106) suggests a Liao Chinese form **fu-žin* (with a final palatal nasal) as the source.

kurV-dī-), a cognate of the Tungusic verb **miakurV-* ‘to kneel’⁶⁹ (Shimunek 2007: 85).

If the Mongolic feminine gender suffix *+gčīn*, the origin of which was partly discussed above, is indeed a complex suffix, its first component can be identified with **+pI*. The original **+pI+čīn* might have developed over **+yIčIn* to the historical *+gčīn* after the syncope. The only other instance of **-p(V)C-* > **-gC-* in Mongolic which is known to me is PM **agta* ‘gelding’ (N: 266) going back over **xagta* to **kap(V)ta*, of which the former is the source of PTg. **xakta(-)* (SSTJa I: 26) and the latter is a cognate of PS **kaptø(-)* ‘castrates’ (Janhunen 1977: 60; Janhunen 1998: 477).⁷⁰ Both PPM **kap(V)ta* and PS **kaptø(-)* seem to have a common source, possibly a Turkic one. As Róna-Tas (1988: 743) has similarly argued for PS **kaptø(-)*, PPM **kap(V)ta* might be an archaic loanword from an unattested Turkic word **kaputā* (< *kap-* ‘to grasp, to seize with hands or teeth’).

Similar feminine gender suffixes containing labial consonants are also found in Turkic and Tungusic. The Middle Turkic words *xanīm* ~ *xanum* (TMEN III No. 1163)⁷¹ and *bāgīm* ~ *bāgüm* (TMEN II No. 831) both of which are used as titles for high-ranked women are derived with the suffix *+Xm* from the bases *xan* and *bāg*, respectively (TMEN I: 34). Although not directly related to the Turkic *+Xm*, the feminine suffix *+mñī* ~ *+mñu* in Evenki (Benzing 1956: 75–76; Bulatova-Grenoble 1999: 16) must also be noted here.

What exhibits a striking similarity to the reconstructed Pre-Proto-Mongolic **+pA* / **+pU* (masc.) and **+pI* (fem.) are the gender suffixes *-pa* (masc.) and *-pi* (fem.) in Meithei, a Tibeto-Burman language spoken in Manipur, occurring in words such as *nupa* ‘male human’ and *nupi* ‘female human’ (Chelliah 1997: 244–245).⁷²

After this discussion, the question arises of itself whether the suffix **+pA* on the ethnonyms **Serpe* and **Argupa*, which have been dealt with above, is identical with the masculine gender suffix **+pA*. However, the question cannot be answered with certainty at present. I am inclined to consider the masculine possessive adjectival suffix *+tU* as an analogical replacement of the earlier and original **+tAyU* (< **+sA+pU*) whereas its feminine counterpart **+sA+pI* has yielded **+tA(y)i* over **+tAyI*.

69 Cf. Jurchen *miyakuru-* (Kiyose 1977: 123); **niekuru-* (Kane 1989: 287); Manchu *niyakūra-* and *niyakūn* (Norman 1978: 216) and other Tungusic forms in SSTJa (I: 536) clearly reflecting **miakura-*. Note that SSTJa (I: 536) gives Mo. *meküi-* ‘to bow’ for the comparison.

70 Cf. Ket *qōpt* ‘castrated reindeer bull’ (← Selkup) (Georg 2007: 84; Vajda 2009: 480, 495), Mansi *χōpt* ‘kastriertes Rentier’ (Steinitz 1955: 175, 345).

71 Beside the given examples, the word also appears as a loanword in Ket *qanam* ~ *qannam* ‘carica’ (Verner 2002: 54), which is erroneously considered by Vajda (2009: 495) to be of Mongolian origin (*qannum* ‘queen’).

72 The Meithei *-pa* and *-pi* go back to the Proto-Tibeto-Burman **pa* ‘father’ and **pwi(y)* ‘female’ (Benedict 1972: 46, 96). In this respect, the Meithei *-pi* has replaced the Proto-Tibeto-Burman feminine gender suffix **-ma* (< **ma* ‘mother’).

If all the forms reconstructed above are brought together, we attain PPM **erim i.se.pü*, which must have signified ‘having (a) maimed eye (masc.)’. PPM **erim isepü* corresponds almost exactly to the Kalmuck phrase *ermdəg nüttē* (< *eremdeg nidütei*). Given the fact that the Mongolic *esüg* surfaces as back vocalic *ᠡᠰᠦᠭ* in Herodotus, PPM **erim isepü* must have surfaced as **Arimisapu*. Herodotus’ Ἀριμασποί is quite close to this form. His etymological explanation that Ἀριμασποί is composed of ἄριμα ‘one’ and ποῦ ‘eye’ is only in partial agreement with PPM **erim* ‘maimed’ and **isepü* ‘eyed, having an eye’. I am convinced that Herodotus had missegmented the word (instead of the correct segmentation **ἄριμ* and **ασποῦ*) and the meanings given by him for the constituent words are simply based on the meaning of the compound word.

6. Conclusion

The first linguistically identifiable Mongolic-speaking people are the Xianbei who dominated eastern Mongolia and Manchuria from the 2nd to the 4th century AD (Golden 1992: 69–72; Rybatzki 2011: 369). The Donghu (東胡), from which the Xianbei emerged, can safely be assumed to have been (at least partly) comprised of Mongolic-speaking people. If we identify the “Argippaeen language” as an ancient predecessor of Mongolic and Para-Mongolic, we have to take into account either an eastward migration of the successors of the Argippaei or a westward migration and isolation of the Argippaei from the Xianbei-Mongolic *Urheimat*. Seeing that the Donghu were first recorded in the 7th century BC in the Chinese sources as having spread in northeastern China and Mongolia, the latter seems more likely. The suggestion of the westward movement of a Mongoloid population in prehistoric Central Asia brings to mind the Dandybay culture tribes that migrated from the east, probably from Siberia, penetrated into Kazakhstan in the 11th century BC, caused a slight Mongoloid admixture among the Europoid Saka of north, central and east Kazakhstan, and was eventually absorbed by the latter (Kuz’mına 2007: 79, 364, 386). The remnants of the Mongoloid Dandybay people in the 7th century BC may well be regarded as the Mongolic-speaking Argippaei which were culturally, however not linguistically, assimilated to the Saka as is reported by Herodotus, even though the argument that the ceramic technique of the Dandybay culture rather relates them to the Turkic-speaking people of Siberia such as the Yakuts and Shors (Kuz’mına 2007: 79, 364) undermines this supposition. Whatever it may be, taking into account the unlikelihood of merely coincidental similarities between Herodotus’ Argippaeen glosses and the Pre-Proto-Mongolic forms, it is almost certain that the language spoken by the Argippaei was an ancient predecessor of the Xianbei-Mongolic language family.

Abbreviations

BTD	Buddhist Transcriptional Dialect (Later Han period)
Bur.	Buryat

Chin.	Chinese
Chuv.	Chuvash
CT	Common Turkic
Dag.	Dagur
dial.	dialectal
DLT	Dīwān Luġāt at-Turk
EMC	Early Middle Chinese
fem.	feminine
fol.	folio
Jur.	Jurchen
HY	Hua-yi Yi-yu
Kalm.	Kalmuck
Khal.	Khalkha
Khit.	Khitan
LH	Later Han Chinese
lit.	literally
Ma.	Manchu
masc.	masculine
MC	Middle Chinese
Mgr.	Monguor
MM	Middle Mongol
Mo.	Mongolic
MT	Middle Turkic
Muh.	Ibn al-Muḥannā (Kitāb ḥilya al-insān wa-ḥalaba al-lisān)
OCM	Old Chinese Minimal
Oir.	Oirat
ONW	Old Northwest Chinese
Ord.	Ordos
OT	Old Turkic
PKM	Proto-Khitano-Mongolic
PM	Proto-Mongolic
PPM	Pre-Proto-Mongolic
PPTg.	Pre-Proto-Tungusic
PS	Proto-Samoyedic
PTg.	Proto-Tungusic
PY	Proto-Yeniseic
SH	The Secret History of the Mongols
Trk.	Turkic
Tuv.	Tuvan
WM	Written Mongol

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而以阿拉伯語言寫的文獻 *özäl* 一詞有幾種字母書寫形式。仍然至今缺乏公認準確的發音與意義，詞幹亦不清楚。

Orçun ÜNAL

On the Language of the Argippaei: An Ancient Predecessor of Mongolic?

The aim of the present study is to show that the language of the Argippaei, first mentioned by Herodotus, is related to the Mongolic and Para-Mongolic languages. This conviction is based on four words given by Herodotus, which are ἄσχυ, ποντικόν, Ἀργιππαῖοι and Ἀριμασποί / Ἀριμάσπεα. Ἄσχυ, which is the name of a drink in the Argippaeian language, is a cognate of the Mongolic **esüg*, which is similarly used to signify sour beverages and koumiss. Ποντικός, which is the name of the tree the fruits of which were used to produce ἄσχυ, is related to the Mongolic *monasun* ‘bird cherry’. This article will link the above terms with Old Uyghur, 鮮卑 Xianbei and Pre-Proto-Mongolic, in order to reconstruct elements of the language of the Argippaei.

Ἀργιππαῖοι 民族的語言：蒙古語言古代的祖先？

古代希臘歷史學家希羅多德（Ἡρόδοτος）兩千五百年前提到了關於中亞地區食品和飲料的幾個詞，這些詞彙來自亞洲的 Ἀργιππαῖοι 民族。而此些詞彙在亞洲其他民族語言中也能找到同源詞。本文通過對這些詞彙及古回鶻語、鮮卑語及山谷蒙古語的分析來重構 Ἀργιππαῖοι 語的語言元素。

WU Pei-lin 吳珮琳

Aesop's Fables in Ancient China

At the beginning of the twentieth century, many expeditions were carried out in the Tarim Basin located in the northwestern part of China (East Turkestan). The remnants of the manuscripts of Aesop's fables were found by Albert von Le Coq in the second German expedition in Gaochang (or Chotscho) in the Turfan area during 1904 to 1905. According to archaeologists' research, they can be dated back to the period between the eighth and twelfth centuries and can be subdivided into Iranian and Old Turkish sources. One of the Iranian fables, “The Father and His Sons” told by Mani, the founder of Manichaeism, is especially noteworthy. A similar story was recorded in the mid-sixth century *Wei shu* (“Book of Wei”) and was subsequently adopted by the Mongolians in the *Menggu mi shi* (“The Secret History of the Mongols”). By exploring the historical background of the transmission of this fable and looking into the Chinese historical records of Manichaeism, this paper aims to prove that not only this Aesopian fable entered China around the mid-sixth century in the form of history, but that other fables might have spread during the eighth century, when Manicheans were active in the Tang empire. This means that Aesop's fables